

Suggest and recommend

Teaching guide

Offer an idea using a natural verb pattern.

Understand the distinction

Use suggest or recommend with a noun or an -ing activity: suggest a cafe; recommend booking early. With a named person doing the action, a that clause is useful: I suggest that she book early. She should book is also possible after that, especially in British English.

Do not use suggest someone to do for advice. Say suggest that someone do, or suggest doing. Recommend has additional patterns and meanings, such as recommend someone for a job. Learn the meaning and pattern together instead of treating both verbs as identical in every use.

Compare the patterns

ACTIVITY

I recommend booking ahead.

Booking is the suggested activity.

PERSON + ACTION

I suggest that Mina call first.

Use the base verb call in this advice pattern.

RECIPIENT

She suggested a cafe to me.

To me identifies the recipient of the suggestion.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the correction: She suggested me to apply.

- A. She suggested that I apply.
- B. She suggested that I to apply.
- C. She suggested to me to apply.

2. Complete: I recommend ___ early. (arrive)

- A. arriving
- B. arrive
- C. to arriving

3. Is I suggest that she should call possible?

- A. Yes, especially in British English.
- B. Yes, but only when giving advice about the past.
- C. No. Should is forbidden after suggest.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which recommendation uses a standard suggest pattern?

- A. I suggest taking an earlier train so you have time to find the office.
- B. I suggest that you to take an earlier train.
- C. I suggest you should taking an earlier train.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. She suggested that I apply.

Suggest does not use the person + to-infinitive advice pattern.

B: After suggested that I, use the base verb apply without to.

C: Use suggested to me that I apply, or suggested that I apply, for this meaning.

2. A. arriving

Use an -ing form for the activity.

B: Recommend takes the -ing form in this pattern: recommend arriving.

C: Do not combine to with arriving in this pattern.

3. A. Yes, especially in British English.

Should + base verb is an accepted alternative.

B: The pattern can give advice about a present or future action.

C: Suggest that someone should do something is an established pattern.

4. A. I suggest taking an earlier train so you have time to find the office.

Suggest can take an -ing form: taking.

B: Use suggest that you take, without to.

C: Should takes the base verb take, not taking.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-17.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which recommendation uses a standard suggest pattern?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.